I got the POWER

Choosing the right UPS for your SoHo can be a pain. Presenting solutions that will put you at ease

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The story goes that a Bangalore-headquartered Uninterruptible Power Supply (UPS) solutions company hates the Mumbai market because power rarely trips out there, and as a result there are few individual buyers. Nevertheless, businesses—both big and small, and whether in Mumbai or elsewhere—have to have UPS systems installed. They just cannot afford to lose any data, or even time, due to power issues.

SoHo users, too, are not immune to these problems. And whatever power problem there may be—a power cut or a power surge—home office users would do well to be prepared for any eventuality. The commonest solution SoHo users employ is a spikebuster, used as defence against power surges. But power-cuts still pose issues.

A UPS device is normally bought as an afterthought, if any money is left after buying the PCs. But a UPS not only keeps work going in case of a power-cut, but also protects machines as an advanced surge protector, and a device that provides clean power supply essential for a PC. All this comes at just a small price, but ensures that your valuable investment stays safe.

Calculate your power needs

This is the tricky part. No matter which UPS company you approach, it would want to sell a high-end solution for your home office or small business, while you will be better off with a solution that is much more attuned to your needs.

Before purchasing a UPS you need to consider your PC's power consumption.

A regular Pentium 4 computer with a generic 17-inch monitor consumes close to 400W or 560VA (Voltamps) of power. We will assume this consumption if the configuration has a single hard drive, 256 MB of RAM and a CD-ROM drive. No printers or other external power consuming equipment have been considered. In such a situation, it would be wise to go in for UPS with 600VA rating.

Also, a UPS falters if the load on it exceeds its rating. So if a 500VA load is applied on to a UPS that provides 500VA of power, you will end up getting only five minutes of back up time. Based on this thumb rule, calculate the VA rating for each device you want connected to the UPS.

Here's an easy way of calculating the VA rating for each device that you have:

1. List all equipment you want connected to the UPS—monitors, hubs, external hard

Illustration Atul Deskmukh

Types of UPS

Offline

The most commonly used UPS, with a pretty simple technology. In the case of power failure, the UPS switches to a battery back-up, and can be used for PCs, given the low cost and high efficiency levels of such systems. This makes it ideal for home PC users.

Online

Also called the true UPS, since the load always runs on the UPS, and the real (Alternating Current or AC) power is only used as secondary power supply. Seems strange? It does, but if the AC power trips, the switch time is immediate, hence leads to minimal or zero loss of up-time.

Line interactive UPS

A type of offline UPS in which the battery remains in charging mode when primary AC power is on. When AC power trips, the battery takes over and provides power. It also monitors voltage fluctuations constantly, and in situations where low voltage conditions exist, the UPS adjusts the power supply instead of switching on to the battery. This means that the UPS works at high efficiencies. This type of UPS is the preferred solution for SoHo, small business and Web server scenarios.